Ratan swayed the workers, saying, ‘I think Tata Tea is a much more comprehensive company than I have ever imagined … I foresee Tata Tea as being in a preeminent place in the global tea industry.’ In his inspiring address, he appreciated the workers’ services and said that he was ‘very proud of Tata Tea’. He added, ‘I sense there is a great sense of pride in what this enterprise stands for, a great sense of belonging and a great sense of participation in where this enterprise is going.’

In 1998, Ratan looked at plans to buy tea estates in Tanzania, Kenya and Uganda. The same year, S.M. Kidwai was appointed as the new MD of Tata Tea while Krishna Kumar took over as MD of Indian Hotels.

Krishna Kumar’s seven-year tenure as MD comprised perhaps the most momentous years in the tea company’s history, during which it also faced the aggressive ULFA unrest. His time witnessed a frenetic pace of inorganic expansion and modernization. For FY 1997–98, the company’s revenue rose to Rs 870 crore and its net profit was Rs 102 crore, a 26 per cent increase in the former and 73 per cent in the latter over the previous year. Tata Tea also became the ‘largest integrated tea company in the world’.

Krishna Kumar stepping down as MD of Tata Tea did not, however, mean that he had let go the reins. He continued to steer the company. Kidwai followed the path of his predecessor. He also continued to push overseas acquisitions.

The year 1999 bore witness to the first large foreign acquisition that Ratan would make. It was a part of his overall strategy that he had prescribed for all Tata companies. The company made a more determined bid for Tetley and bagged it. When the acquisition was completed in 2000, it was the biggest deal by any Indian company until then. It was also a personal triumph for Krishna Kumar. He had personally steered the largest foray as yet by the Tatas into the territory of India’s erstwhile colonial masters. A leading newspaper termed the £271 million acquisition as ‘one of his [Krishna Kumar’s] finest achievements’, that ‘not only catapulted Tata Global Beverages to the No. 2 spot among the world’s tea makers but also brought the group and India Inc on to the international stage’.

In the midst of the expansion spree, Ratan did not forget to implement the less visible pillars of his restructuring programme. He pushed for the ‘pursuit of excellence’ under the TBEM initiative by introducing and refining several ‘business processes’.